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**REPORT OF FREE COMMUNITY HEALTH FAIR AND OUTREACH ORGANISED BY JOYFUL HEALTH
FOUNDATION AT IKPEREJERE COMMUNITY**

Presented by Dr Patrick Desmond Osita.

INTRODUCTION

This year's 2023 free community health fair and Outreach Organised by Joyful Health Foundation with its CEO Dr Philip Okeke and Co was successfully executed and completed at Ikperejere community. The Outreach took place between 18th- 21st December 2023 with the Theme "Health is Wealth".

The medical outreach was attended by team of professionals ranging from medical doctors, Optometrist, Medical laboratory Scientist and Nurses as well as the Non health administrative workers that worked tirelessly to achieve the Objectives of the Organisation.

Ikperejere is a peace loving and Hospitable Community situated in Ihetteuboma Local Government Area of Imo State Nigeria.

The Four (4) days free medical outreach accorded the residents of Ikperejere and nearby communities the opportunity to know their health status by providing them access to various multi-disease testing and counselling services as well as treatment. It was an avenue for free medical consultation, laboratory screening and eye Checkup. Several other ailments were diagnosed and treated by medical doctors.

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THE HEALTH OUTREACH

The free medical outreach started on Monday 18th to Thursday 21st December 2023 from 9am to 5pm daily At Umuhie Town Hall in Ikperejere.

A briefing of the medical team was done before the outreach commenced. The CEO through the head of the medical team emphasized the need for collaborative effort and team work among the health professionals. He also buttressed on the need for establishment of good rapport with members of the community.

There was a huge turnout of members of the community and neighbouring communities to the outreach venue which is traceable to the fact that a proper awareness and advocacy concerning the outreach was done. More than Eight Hundred and Forty (840) persons were reached out to. Some were diagnosed with different kinds of diseases and treated as well.

The free medical outreach started with prayers followed by sensitization and conscientization of the members of the community on the need for regular health check up and treatment.

The Outreach encompassed getting the bio-demographic data of the Clients/ Patients, checking of vital signs, free consultation, free prescription drugs, free eye Checkup and issuance of appropriate glasses for the various eye defects.

There were referrals to appropriate health facilities when needed. Patients/Clients were also given free qualitative laboratory screening by medical laboratory scientist on request by the doctors. Various tests/screening which includes:

- Blood Glucose level Test (fasting and random blood sugar levels)
- Malaria Parasite Test
- Helicobacter Pylori Test
- Typhoid Screening
- Retroviral Screening for HIV
- Hepatitis B screening, Etc.

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The eye unit was manned by two clinical optometrists and the clinical procedures carried out during the outreach include:

- Visual Acuity test
- Ophthalmoscopy
- Penlight examination
- Subjective Refraction

150 Reading glasses were dispensed to Presbyopic individuals who are lettered.

Ocular topical drugs were also prescribed for diagnosed eye conditions which includes but not limited to the following;

- Allergic Conjunctivitis
- Vernal kerato-conjunctivitis
- Primary open angle glaucoma
- Immature Cataract
- Corneal foreign Body
- Bacterial Conjunctivitis
- Optic Atrophies
- Diabetic Retinopathy

FINDINGS/OBSERVATIONS

- The number of Patients/Clients recorded were so many and beyond the expected numbers budgeted for. It shows how much people need health care delivery in that community and by extrapolation the state and the country Nigeria at large.
- The venue(Town Hall) was overstretched and its carrying capacity exceeded hence the need for expansion in further outreaches.
- There is a high prevalence of Primary Open Angle Glaucoma among the inhabitants of Ikperejere and it's neighboring villages. It was noticed that 1 out of every 4 patients have signs and symptoms of glaucoma.

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- Cataract and pterygium were moderately common, most of the cataract cases were secondary to trauma while the rest were senile cataracts (age related).
- Allergic Conjunctivitis were common but can be easily linked to the current weather and poor hygiene.
- The moderate prevalence of Refractive errors among young adults and children was a concern because nothing much was done for these categories and that's because the lenses available were for only older adults (presbyopes).

- Finally, it was observed that 90% or more had issues of not being able to read their bibles and other materials.

Also, the common illness/disease prevalent includes

- Scabies
- Malaria
- Hypertension
- Diabetes Mellitus
- Allergic conjunctivitis.

Two(2) cases of positive screening for HIV was recorded and both of them who happened to be couples and unaware of their HIV status were referred to nearby Federal Medical Centre for confirmatory test and possible management.

A case of positive HBsAg was noted and was referred to Federal Medical Centre Umuahia for gastroenterology care.

Three(3) cases of uncontrolled Asthma was noted and the parents of the children were counselled properly and referred to FMC Umuahia for proper management.

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CHALLENGES

- Giving of palliative (food stuff) after the medical checkup as seen this year posed difficulty to doctors because parents would literally send their children and other young adults with no medical problems to tell lies simply to get medication so they can by extension get the palliatives.
- There was no medication for scabies in the prescription drug list hence it was prescribed for them to buy
- There was no device for the determination of body mass Index.
- The manual Sphygmomanometer wasn't effective due to the crowded and Noisy environment hence digital Sphygmomanometer is better recommended.

RECOMMENDATION

- There is much need for health care delivery especially this type of outreach programme as it affords the indigent and aged members of the community an opportunity to take care of their health needs.
- There should be follow up for major cases and provision of machinery for emergency health delivery in such outreach in case of emergency.
- More reading glasses should be made available (500pics and above) to cover the huge number of presbyopes in the village.
- More glaucoma drugs should be available considering that 25% of every target population are likely to be glaucoma patients.
- Eye surgeons can be included in the program for cataract extractions and pterygium excisions as these conditions are vision threatening.
- Already made single vision lenses for people with simple refractive errors should be made available to cover for the little population of non presbyopes with refractive errors, this population include majorly school children and young adults

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- Future outreach provision should be made for determining BMI.
- Purchase of More digital Sphygmomanometer
- Purchase of thermometer
- Purchase of more antihistamine drugs considering the season (cold and dusty season) during which the outreach is been held.

CONCLUSION

Despite these challenges, the outreach was successfully managed, executed and completed and its desired objectives achieved. Kudos to JOYFUL HEALTH FOUNDATION!

God bless Dr Philip Okeke!

God bless JOYFUL HEALTH FOUNDATION!

God bless the good people of Ikperejere community in Ihitte Uboma Local Government Area of Imo State,
God bless Nigeria!

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